

THE
COMMUNICATIONS
AND ELECTRONICS BRANCH

95 CRAFTSMAN BOULEVARD
CFB KINGSTON, ONTARIO, K7K 7B4



BRANCHE
DES COMMUNICATIONS
ET DE L'ÉLECTRONIQUE

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BFC KINGSTON, ONTARIO, K7K 7B4

1000-5 (Br Adjt)

20 May 2022

Distribution List

BRANCH ADVISORY COUNCIL
RECORD OF DECISIONS – FRIDAY, 20 MAY 2022

RECORD OF ATTENDANCE

POSITION / APPOINTMENT	RANK & NAME
Chair / Branch Leader	Brigadier-General James Lambert
Co-Chair / Branch Advisor	Colonel John Roper
Member / Colonel Commandant	Brigadier-General Josée Robidoux (Retired)
Member / Branch Chief	Chief Warrant Officer Gilles Philibert
Member / Director Signals Representative	Lieutenant-Colonel Dan McKinney
Member / Strategic A6	Colonel Alan Ferriss
Member / Comd CFIOG	Colonel Mark Parsons
Member / Home Station Commandant	Lieutenant-Colonel Bahir Ali
Member / Incoming Branch Adjutant	Major Gavin Ellis
Guest / NCM Council Member	Chief Warrant Officer Shawn Mailer
Guest / NCM Council Member	Chief Warrant Officer Alex Arndt
Guest / NCM Council Member	Chief Warrant Officer Pascal Turcotte
Guest / NCM Council Member	Chief Warrant Officer John MacKenzie
Guest / NCM Council Member	Chief Warrant Officer James Marshall
Guest / Home Station RSM	Chief Warrant Officer Rob Sherman
Secretariat / Branch Adjutant	Major Blair Christie

INTRODUCTORY REMARKS

- **General Lambert:**

Provided introductory remarks to the BAC, highlighting the intent to resume mess dinners and social engagements in time for C&E Week 2022. Consideration for this meeting is to keep matters succinct; offline follow-up may be needed to keep meeting moving in the interest of time.

- **General Robidoux:**

1st BAC since assuming the Colonel Commandant appointment. Discussion on C&E Week of interest. In-person C&E Week with mess dinner her hopeful expectation and intent.

- **Colonel Roper:**

Lots to discuss – points may need BL concurrence. Key question: What is the type of C&E Week we are looking for? Senate meeting following this virtual engagement soonest.

INCOMING BRANCH APPOINTMENTS & INCUMBENTS

- Major Gavin Ellis is the incoming Branch Adjutant, replacing Major Blair Christie
- Chief Warrant Officer Alex Arndt is the incoming Branch Chief, replacing Mr. Gilles Philibert
- General Lambert is retiring this summer, replacing Branch Leader to be announced via CANFORGEN once the office of the VCDS reviews and endorses General Lambert's replacement from the pool of submissions. MTF.

C&E WEEK 2022: PROPOSAL AND SUGGESTIONS

- C&E Week 2022: Mon, 24 until Fri, 28 Oct 22
- The standard set of activities, by custom and convention, are pre-programmed in:
 - Carruthers Gravesite Ceremony
 - Exercise NOBLE SKYWAVE
 - Subalterns' & Sergeants' Indoctrination Programme
 - Officers' and NCMs' Mess Dinners
 - Branch Update (to include the H&A portion)
- Mess dinner planners must remain mindful of restrictions. Current plan is to go forward and keep CFB Kingston Base Comd Suite informed and co-ord.
- Senior Occupation Advisors need to devise separate briefs for (1) BAC, (2) Senate, (3) Indoc, and (4) Branch Update to ensure similar messaging is avoided.
- We need ideas for extra C&E Week events, and OPIs who are interested and able to flesh them out into worthwhile events.
- Not only *golden triangle* participation. TD ceilings will continue to limit in-person involvement, but are expected to relax from the heavy restrictions imposed last year. C&E Week 2022 will be a hybrid of in-person and virtual attendance.
- Exercise COMM PLAYER potentially nested inside C&E Week, or alternatively pushed to proper calendar item in March 2023. 1st CoA does posit a C&E Week event option outside of briefings.
- Colonel Commandant's personal feeling / opinion (echoed by several other BAC members) is that people are not looking for more briefings. We should dedicate resources to explore what is feasible (competitions – sports, skill-at-arms, drill, etc.).
- In keeping with dispersed members outside Kingston, we should have multiple concurrent mess dinners or parties; all connect to us for the Branch Leader's Mess Dinner address at the opening portion, then dial-out and resume your own activities.

- In the past, a well-received event included in Industry engagement, and displays of new technology. Troops provided a venue to see new tools, developments, and kit. Plus, these displays are ‘virtual friendly’ and can tap into dispersed personnel. Once CoA could be to reach out to units who’ve done this before such as ATESS.
- Soldiering skills, range day, skill-at-arms, and silent drill competitions / pace-stick drill, etc. present additional opportunities for junior soldiers to engage in C&E Week and show off soldier / unit achievement and pride.
- General John Leech (by proxy) asks *‘what can the C&E Association do for the Branch, especially during C&E Week?’* The Association is a resource of veterans and volunteers that wants to champion something. Case-in-point: they could – if asked – serve as a co-ord agency between industry and military units for the displays and cyber capabilities noted above, and advocate with industry using their contacts within the Association.
- Briefings, when done (such as the Indoc Course) must centre on the relevance of middle managers / leaders; take them aside and discuss issues relevant to them. Plus, reiterate why the why the Branch is important and why it is relevant to them.

ACTION ITEM(s):

- **ALCON:**
All events, where feasible, to include virtual attendance options. Discussions with Tech OPIs – including DIMEUS (for MS Teams Live Events support) must happen soonest.
- **ALCON:**
L1 representatives (CA RCCS / RCAF CELE & ATIS / CFIOG / IM Group / CANSOF) must push expected number of participants to Branch Adjutant soonest IOT start initial work on DRAFT Event Request (ER), due to the Branch Leader NLT End-June 2022.
- **Major Christie:**
Submit DRAFT ER to Branch Leader NLT End-June once attendance numbers are sourced from participating L1 agencies.

▪ **Colonel Roper & CWO Philibert:**

Reach out to Command Teams of Kingston four (4) main signal units and confirm OPIs for:

- Exercise NOBLE SKYWAVE
- Subalterns' & Sergeants' Indoctrination Programme
- Officers' Mess Dinner
- NCMs' Mess Dinner

▪ **Colonel Roper:**

Liaise with CO CFJSR to confirm (1) the Regiment's role as OPI of the Gravesite Ceremony, and (2) if Exercise COMM PLAYER is expected to launch during C&E Week 2022.

▪ **ALCON:**

Canvass your subordinate units and contacts to see if there is interest in setting up any of the following / any other event. A suitable OPI shall be needed to flesh-out the CONOP, SCRIT (Scoring Criteria), DTG, location, venue, OPORD / Instruction generation, and award considerations (the Branch Office can assist with limited funding, advertising, and registration):

- **Range Shoot** competition (rifle & pistol with different ranges and obstructions)
- **Skill-at-Arms** (CFJSR's *Versutus Cup* is an example / building block in which each team has a signaller from each MOSID who must lead the other members in a task related to their profession – e.g. a downed RRB must be set-up and made FOC, the competition also has a range component and obstacle course)
- **Silent Drill** Competition followed by a Pace-Stick assessment by the marching NCO. The course shall require a set of mandatory drill manoeuvres followed by a free-style segment. The Marching NCO will then need to conduct a rehearsal of pace stick manoeuvres IAW the Drill manual. Ranks: Sig / Avr to Sgt. Assessors: MWOs appointed Sergeant-Major.
- **Networking** Competition in which teams set-up networks and establish connections to other teams and then launch an e-game challenge as phase 2.

- **Colonel Roper:**

Provide D&G / structure / CONOP for each briefing for the Occupational Advisors as required to as to fashion proper briefs for the (1) BAC, (2) Senate, (3) Indoc, and (4) Branch Update.

- **Colonel Roper & Colonel Ferriss:**

Liaise with General John Leech of the C&E Association along with previous units engaged with Industry displays and launch initial conversations to test the viability of a C&E Week event, get

- **Subalterns' & Sergeants' Indoctrination Course Officer:**

Planning Guidance – centre on the relevance of middle managers / leaders; take them aside and discuss issues relevant to them. Plus, reiterate why the why the Branch is important and why it is relevant to them.

BATTLEFIELD STUDY TOUR 2023: PROGRESS REPORT

- LCol (Ret'd) Janssen is still the lead and is working with the same committee member.
- Soon-to-be promoted LCol Louis Lemaire remains as the Tour Commander.
- Merit Travel re-engaged.
- ER in for initial review – seeking approval for 5 x members to travel on TD.
- Note: over the last 3-4 years it has proven difficult to garner RCAF interest / involvement.
Consider a comms plans IOT increase interest of all members.
- Current comms plan / outreach plan involves the Branch Leadership in partnership with the Occupation Advisors to '*flavour*' the message in a way that raises interest in Branch membership.
- In its early stage, the BF Tour was not well socialized with the C&E Family and Branch leadership. C&E Family Battle Rhythm must be involved from the start and take on major event suggestions in the future.
- Home Station perspective: These events are not resonating. Simple solution ... SURVEY
(put together a survey to attract feedback and to gain majority of consent.

ACTION ITEM(s):

- **Branch Officer (Adjutant and Home Station Staff Officer):**

Follow-up with DIMCBM to see status of BF Study Tour ER submission.

CMCEN: INFORMATION ACCESS

- Branch Advisor proposes that CMCEN uploads all info: RoDs, Committee reports, governance documents, SOPs, etc. from the various Branch agencies to add a tier of transparency.
- Stop asking for money for everything we post (death, promotion, retirement, etc.)
- The Branch Leader attests that he is *'not one to canvass for money.'* However, the museum is expensive to operate, and support for the brick & mortar institution is eroding (likely a Senate action item and discussion point as there is less & less money).
- CMCEM can mention / advertise that the workplace charitable campaign (NDWCC) is a source to donate money and so long as you have the registered donation codes for the Foundation / Museum, your money will go directly to that account. We can leverage CMCEN to channel this money in. Note that we can lose 20% of money as overage / admin costs.

ACTION ITEM(s):

- **Branch Staff:**
(1) create a location in CMCEN to upload documents and consult with the CMCEN Admin to properly organize and structure it replete with naming conventions for each file, and (2) confirm NDWCC museum code / number and upload donation link and D&G to direct money to the Museum / Foundation.

BRANCH BUDGET

- NSTR – Account sits at \$14,000.00 and zero money was requested from the Foundation as we still have sufficient funds to manage events and objectives. The Foundation is always available to assist where / when needed (such as Distress Funding).

BRANCH HONOURS & AWARDS

- D&G on Branch H&A is on CMCEN and the Standing Orders:
 - CMCEN (Under H&A Banner):
<https://cmcen-rcmce.ca/>
 - Standing Orders (Internal Site):
[https://collaboration-img.forces.mil.ca/sites/CandEBranch/Standing%20Orders/C&E%20Branch%20Standing%20Orders%20\(2020\).pdf](https://collaboration-img.forces.mil.ca/sites/CandEBranch/Standing%20Orders/C&E%20Branch%20Standing%20Orders%20(2020).pdf)
 - Standing Orders (External Site):
<https://cmcen-rcmce.ca/wp-content/uploads/2021/10/CE-Branch-Standing-Orders-2020-1.pdf>
- Branch Commendations x 2 (1 x delivered, 1 x pending presentation)
- SoTY / MoTY – e-mail released to NCM Counsel as a reminder. We'd like to get nominations into the Adjt by Mid-Late June 2022.
- Educational Bursary – Mid-July submission.
- Heritage Award – NSTR.
- Colonel-in-Commendation – submission in the works
- Colonel Ferriss asks: 'can we make SoTY and MoTY members of the BAC for that year? The Branch Chief confirms that the MoTY has been made a member of the NCM Council.

ACTION ITEM(s):

- **ALCON:**
Review Branch H&A and endeavour to push nominations to the Branch Adjt and Chief. From there, nomination boards shall be staffed.
- **Major Christie and CWO Philibert:**
Review / amend staff work as needed on H&A to announce that SoTY and MoTY are part of the BAC and related councils (there is messaging to this effect already noted).

ENVIRONMENTAL BRIEFS / SITREP:

▪ **RCCS (LCol McKinney):**

There is a systemic disengagement problem. Morale is an issue impacting the RCCS. This will, in turn, influence engagement with events & activities. We should not be too quick to conclude that people are not engaged because what we're selling isn't any good ... there are other issues underneath.

See attached slide-deck for State-of-the-Corps by numbers / years:

- 2012-13 (start of scale): 3016 personnel
- 2023-23 (Now): 2294
- 2028-29 (end of chart): 1988.

CURSIT: 50% manning for the Army; a bit better for other L1s regarding their RCCS personnel.

However, recruiting and BTL numbers are showing a potential turn-around ... On the good side:

- #1 – Army Commander said that Digital Transformation in the VITAL Ground.
- #2 – CFSCE cut the BTL in ½ meaning that more troops en route to man the Army units and efforts at the forefront to attain OFT.
- #3 – Approximately 4-6 billion in C2IS investments in the forecast (modern systems replacing legacy suites which, hopefully, should increase morale and meaning).
- #4 – Force 2025 (a Signal Regiment is only new unit being created).

Summary: we can start focusing and reinforcing on the positive developments. There is an optimistic forecast made only stronger with an engaged leadership.

COVID stemmed COMM PLAYER from L1 ER endorsement for max involvement. Should aim to bring it back.

▪ **General Lambert:**

Upon promotion, Colonel McKinney shall be appointed DLCI and Director Signals.
Congratulations extended for his achievements.

▪ **RCAF CELE / ATIS (Col Ferriss):**

CELE Officer = good news. Remote work, flex work, and mentorship programme = retention concerns addressed. NEW CELE positions created has plateaued. 26-30 students per year can maintain projected 96-97% PML. CELE Officers also tasked to a lot of non-CELE positions such as EAs, Aides-de-Camp, etc. to make up for RCAF shortfalls overall. Lastly, COPC programme – in virtual delivery model – proved very effective / successful.

ATIS Tech = not good news. Cannot stem downward direction. Not likely to improve for a while. Digitalization is key. Demand for networks and cyber is pulling ATIS Techs away to other fields & departments. Remote work was not optimal or N/A altogether due to nature of hands-on work. To mitigate:

- 1st – applied for recruiting allowance;
- 2nd – requested an Occupation Analysis (to cover such areas as outsourcing RADAR maintenance to contractors);
- 3rd – Increased SIP and liaised with Recruiting Group to highlight ATIS Techs for marketing, adverts, and engagement across universities and colleges; and
- 4th – seek to decrease time to OFP (reduced classroom time at CFSCE) and leverage college time, etc. in concert with 2 CAD.

CFIOG SIG INT / Cyber (Col Parsons):

Cyber Op: Competition ... approximately 500 (+/-) cyber CSE positions – and related agencies – will draw from the Cyber Ops MOSID pool (currently serving and interested members). Better talent management required in the CM (D Mil C 5) shop. That said, demand for Cyber remains huge. We are refusing people at the attraction level due to projected intake, and we are not referring them for other tech trades (e.g. Sig Tech and ATIS Techs). Consultation is required with CMP to discuss input options. Cyber Op is a time-consuming intake: 10 months (University) + 4 months (CFSCE) + QL5 (additional 4-5 months University). We are deploying Cyber Operators.

Sig Int Specs: There are Sig Int Specs who've remained on the BTL for 4 years due to security clearance backlogs and related issues. Waivers needed to get them to OFP and out of the school, but TSSA, and polygraph exams still need to be done and impede ability to work.

No off-ramp options to RCCS or ATIS professions. We want to address processing backlogs and get them into their MOSID of choice.

Officers = Cyber Officer Study moving. Pushing a SIGINT Officer and a Cyber Officer (aware of Bank of Canada and CSE draw) will cause further issues for Sig O and CELE O. Once these are created, we expect a heavy interest and draw from current positions under their MOSID scope.

OPEN FORUM / ROUND TABLE / QUESTION PERIOD

▪ **Commandant CFSCE (LCol Ali):**

You will see a return on investment to your orgs if you invest in CFSCE. 10 x fold returned. 1 x instructor yields 10 x graduates. CFSCE also provides excellent leadership development tools for *'the missing middle'* as the school can develop great leaders (develop, mentor, motivate, and inspire leaders through the instructor cadre plan). Lastly, CFSCE is putting in place initiatives zeroize the BTL this calendar year and get pre-OFP candidates out to the field force, and make concerted efforts – through OJT and other packages – to expedite plans to help them achieve OFP soonest.

▪ **Incoming Director Signals (LCol McKinney):**

It is worth reminding that the best recruiters are recent recruits. We've been killing off our best recruiters from the beginning. Zeroize the BTL is excellent to bolster numbers and provide positive experience to our newest members, who will relay this information to others.

▪ **Colonel Commandant (BGen Robidoux):**

A C&E Senate meeting is planned 2 x weeks from now.



Brigadier-General James Lambert, CD
Branch Leader



Colonel John Roper, CD
Branch Advisor